undermine recent improvements in Indo-Pakistani relations and increase the probability of crises between the two countries.

Second, Indian doctrinal changes increase the likelihood that Indo-Pakistani crises will escalate rapidly, both within the conventional sphere and from the conventional to the nuclear level. In the conventional realm, Cold Start will enable Indian forces to attack Pakistan quickly, pushing an Indo-Pakistani dispute from the level of political crisis to outright conflict before the Indian government can be deterred from launching an offensive. Vijay Oberoi explains that the decision to attack Pakistan would require "a certain amount of political will. But [Cold Start] makes that political will more likely to be there, since now we can mobilize before world opinion comes down on political leaders and prevents them from acting."[74]

In the nuclear realm, India's Cold Start doctrine would likely force Pakistan to rely more heavily on its strategic deterrent. Brigadier General Khawar Hanif, Pakistan's former defense attaché to the United States, argued that Cold Start will create a "greater justification for Pakistani nuclear weapons" and may increase the danger of nuclear use. "The wider the conventional asymmetry," he maintains, "the lower the nuclear threshold between India and Pakistan. To the extent that India widens the conventional asymmetry through military spending and aggressive doctrinal changes, the nuclear threshold will get lower." Major General Muhammad Mustafa Khan, former director-general (analysis) of Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence agency, similarly held that Cold Start "is destabilizing; it is meant to circumvent nuclear deterrence and warning time, . . . [and] it is entirely Pakistan-specific. . . . This will force us to undertake countermeasures," he continues, "and if it becomes too threatening we will have to rely on our nuclear capability."[75] Cold Start thus may erode the firebreak between conventional and nuclear conflict on the subcontinent.

The Indians reportedly anticipate such an outcome at the tactical level and are preparing to fight through Pakistani battlefield nuclear strikes.[76] However, Indian strategists dismiss the possibility of a Pakistani nuclear response against India proper. The Indians maintain that they can carefully calibrate their attack, stopping short of Pakistan's strategic nuclear thresholds and waiting for